Abhishek in the past, but have now mended ties. Abhishek has also created an inner circle of his own, with new faces such as Debangshu Bhattacharya (head of the party's IT cell) and Saayoni Ghosh (head of the TMC youth wing), as well as veterans like Partha Bhowmick (Barrackpore MP) and Sujit Bose (junior minister in Mamata's cabinet).

EYE ON THE ELECTION

The ultimate prize, of course, will be the 2026 assembly poll. The arrangement is clear: Mamata remains the ultimate authority, Abhishek the operations chief. Since August, he has been meeting workers and leaders from the districts in a series of virtual meetings. On the national stage, he's increasingly becoming the party's primary face, chosen to represent the TMC in the post-Operation Sindoor all-party delegation that led India's global outreach.

Over the years, Abhishek has shown a maturity far beyond his years. After the BJP won as many as 18 LS seats in 2019, poll strategist Prashant Kishor was brought in at his insistence and a third of the TMC's sitting MLAs were dropped for the 2021 assembly poll. The party won 215 of the 294 seats then. That gave Abhishek leverage, which he used to fight the endemic corruption in the party. He demanded a reshuffle of leaders' duties when the party was rocked by scams—campaigns that saw him taking on veterans and incurring their wrath. His 2023 Trinamooley Nobo Jowar outreach programme, which took him across Bengal before the panchayat polls, was another eye-opener. Seeing how the masses suffered without the vital help that NREGA offers, the tour crystallised his decision to make Bengal's pending dues a main theme for the 2024 LS polls campaign.

"Abhishek has a refreshingly sharp mind. He thinks like a professional and is always coming up with new ideas," says Bengal's education minister Bratya Basu. A veteran TMC MP who once harboured misgivings says he, too, has reversed his opinion. "There is no one better placed to carry forward Didi's legacy. Abhishek is emotional but restrained; quiet but attentive. These are characteristics that make a leader," he says. The only critique he offers: Mamata's nephew could be more accessible to cadre and the public.



"Abhishek Banerjee has a sharp mind. It is refreshing to talk to him. He thinks like a professional and comes up with new ideas"

BRATYA BASU
TMC leader, West Bengal education minister



"Irrespective of who is at its helm, Mamata or Abhishek, TMC will always be corrupt... which is why the people of Bengal will throw them out in the next election"

SAMIK BHATTACHARYA
State BJP chief

National general secretary since 2021, Abhishek has also proven himself as a crisis manager. He led the damage control exercise in July 2022 after the teacher's recruitment scam blew up in the party's face. With the Election Commission announcing a revision of voter rolls in Bengal before the 2026 election, he is now gearing up for what may be the biggest fight of them all—against what the TMC fears will be a "disenfranchisement of valid voters" in Bengal. That battle will have national visibility.

TAINT IN THE MIX

Challenges remain, of course. Abhishek's name continues to be linked to controversies like the alleged coal scam and teachers' recruitment scam. Central probe agencies have questioned him in both cases. In a third chargesheet related to the latter scam in February 2025, the CBI named an 'Abhishek Banerjee' without specifying anything more—critics insist it is the TMC MP. The allegations have not hurt his prospects, but they do provide rivals with ammunition. "Like all regional parties, TMC is family-centric," says state BJP chief Samik Bhattacharya. "And they tend to be to autocratic, which in turn breeds corruption. Irrespective of who is at the helm, Mamata or Abhishek, TMC will always be a corrupt party...which is why the people of Bengal will throw them out in the next election."

CPI(M) state secretary Mohammed Salim has a similar take on the aunt and nephew, saying the TMC has introduced a "culture of feudalism" where the party and state administration revolve round the "whims of Abhishek". Salim also points to the old allegations of electoral malpractices in Diamond Harbour, with opponents alleging that it is "ghost voters" who drive Abhishek's victories here. "While the INDIA bloc is busy cornering the BJP on its industrial scale of rigging...Abhishek himself has been industrious in manipulating elections; that is how he has won poll after poll in Diamond Harbour," he says.

But then these are allegations. If Abhishek's career till now is taken in context, it is one that has been shaped by quiet victories and a strategic accretion of power. A victory in the 2026 assembly election could be the icing on the cake, transforming his role from inheritor-in-waiting to a leader whose time has come. ■